

Prelude to the Tet Offensive

Through the summer and fall of 1967, the NVA and Viet Cong attacked American bases along the DMZ. Their aim was to draw US and ARVN forces into these areas and clear the way for a major communist assault on South Vietnam's cities and towns.

◀◀ BEFORE

When intensive US bombing of North Vietnam failed to end the war, US Defense Secretary Robert McNamara looked for other solutions.

HIGH-TECH DEFENSE

McNamara decided that the war could only be won by stopping **NVA soldiers and supplies from infiltrating South Vietnam**. He proposed the construction of a high-tech barrier across the **DMZ** to cut off the **Ho Chi Minh Trail**.

Scientists in the Pentagon proposed all kinds of **devices to help secure the line**. In addition to the more usual barbed wire and minefields, they included "button" bombs the size of a beetle, bomb-dropping carrier pigeons, electronic sensors affixed to live insects, and acoustic devices to "listen" for the enemy (the only ones that were actually used).

On September 7, 1967, Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara held a news conference to announce the construction of an infiltration barrier across the DMZ. The McNamara Line, as it became known, was intended to link a chain of new or reinforced firebases from the border with Laos to the South China Sea. However, when construction of the line began, North Vietnamese artillery harassed the construction crews to such an extent that General Westmoreland was forced to limit the project to firebases at Con Thien, Dak To, and Khe Sanh.

Meanwhile, the NVA high command, planning their "general offensive," saw how they could use the American firebases to their advantage. If they could lure US and ARVN units away from their urban strongholds to firebases around South Vietnam, their offensives in Saigon and other major cities would have a greater chance of success.

Attack on Con Thien

Located in Quang Tri province just 14 miles (23 km) inland from the coast and 2 miles (3 km) south of the DMZ, Con Thien ("Hill of Angels") firebase came under attack on May 8, 1967, as US Marines repulsed an intense NVA ground assault with bloody hand-to-hand combat. Fighting continued around the firebase throughout the summer as the Marines and their ARVN allies launched counterattacks to find and destroy NVA bunkers and artillery emplacements.

By the end of the summer, the NVA was bombarding Con Thien daily with long-range howitzers based across the DMZ. The Marines drove back an NVA ground assault before it could breach the inner defensive wire, but in the Siege of Con Thien, from September 19 to September 27, thousands of artillery and mortar rounds rained down on the beleaguered Marines. The US forces responded with their own massive bombardment from land, sea, and air—a barrage that eventually broke the siege.